the Russian Revolution did little to change. Indeed, so convinced was Britain of the hostile intentions of Russia towards its empire that the term ‘Russophobia’ was even coined to describe such a fear.

The phenomenon of Russophobia has not received as much attention as it warrants, given its importance within the milieu of Anglo-Russian relations. Yet the term was one recognised by contemporaries and certainly had a role to play within both official and unofficial discourse on Russia. Russophobia was a hostility by certain people in Britain towards Russia, sometimes manifesting itself as an almost obsessive hysteria. In particular, Russophobes tended to view that country with a level of distrust that could not be countered by any Russian official.[63] In effect, no matter what Russia said or did, a Russophobe always attributed the worst of intentions to that country. Literature was one particular area which thrived on Russophobia, with writers such as William Le Queux both epitomising Russophobia and also serving to exacerbate the phenomenon, casting Russia as the principal enemy in adventure and spy fiction. Invariably in such novels, the Russian was ‘the picture of savagery’ – brutal, uncivilised and criminal. Russian invasion of India, Constantinople, and even England itself, was a further common theme, as was the despotic nature of the tsarist government.[64] While it is notoriously difficult to define ‘public opinion’, and even harder to track the effect of such popular expression on official policy, the views of the British population towards Russia ‘exerted a definite, if subtle and hard-to-quantify influence on the general relations between the two countries’.[65] Russophobia was an important facet of British decision-making towards Russia in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. As will be shown, Curzon provides a prime example of a British official whose Russophobia affected his opinion of Bolshevik Russia.

What is readily apparent from even the limited amount of literature is the continual reiteration, both within official and popular discourse, that Russia was a military threat to Britain and its empire. For all the apparent distaste of liberals regarding the tsarist regime, it was the ability of Russia to mobilise thousands of its men in opposition to Britain which ultimately fuelled Russophobia. In particular, the fear regarding the security and stability of India dominated British policy towards Russia and South Asia throughout this period. This obsession with India governed Britain’s